

Tom Clancy's HAWX

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into tweeting from your phone, and a tweeter is bound to walk into a toilet with the phone in his pocket. Sooner or later, there comes a point in every tweeter's life, where they are sitting on a pot with the phone between their fingers. A search on Twitter should yield the results for those interested in what happens next. However, there are some people who have gone far beyond what is perfectly natural.

Randy Sarafan learned of Twitter and found one fundamental philosophical problem which every tweeter faces eventually. Twitter encourages you to answer the question, "What are you doing?" Now the problem is this — if you are doing something, you are doing it, and not tweeting. If however, you are tweeting, what you are "doing" is tweeting, which means you can't be doing anything else. You can tweet you are breathing, reading what you are typing, and typing, but that's about it. This problem makes the whole of the tweetosphere a lie. When people tweet about what they are doing, they have already done it, or at least, taken a break to tweet. The best normal tweeple can hope for was to tweet as soon as they had done something. This just wasn't good enough for Randy Sarafan, he wanted to tweet as he was doing some things. What Randy Sarafan wanted to do was to ensure that there is no tweet lag.

Now to ensure that the tweets are realtime, there had to be some mechanism which would tweet developments automatically. Now Randy Sarafan was your regular everyday guy in at least some respects, and spent most of his day sitting on a chair. What kind of activity, could a chair possibly update in real time? Why, the discharge of bodily gasses of course. Now the clever bit was building the chair, the entire set of instructions are available at tinyurl.com/o29jek. Randy got his ultra-cool toolbox out, which included a laser cutter by the way, and rigged together a chair that tweets every time he farts. The most important component, is a natural gas detector. The component used is of industrial strength, and is primarily used for detecting dangerous leaks. This leads us to understand that Randy's "leaks" are



pretty dangerous, and the unfortunate chair that tweets every time it is farted on, thoroughly reflects this. You don't need to read much between the few lines at twitter.com/officechair to make out the desperate pleas for help. The chair didn't see that one coming, you see, and we are pretty sure, neither did you.

The sane-as-Dr-No guys at hacklab.to thought that the 1337est h4XX0r HQ on planet earth required the 1337est h4XX0r

toilet on planet earth. You probably guessed the rest. Yes, they rigged the toilet so that every time someone flushes, it tweets about it (twitter.com/hacklabtoilet).

The simple part was fixing a mechanism that records the flush, and

then relaying it using a dedicated Ethernet connection. Yes, some people's toilets have net access, while others don't even have toilet access! The difficult part came out later (no, not that way), when they started testing it. There were a number of considerations they had to make. For example, a single flush may not actually take care of the matter, so it is sometimes necessary to flush multiple times. Tweeting these instances must be avoided, so they set up a time-delay between consecutive flush-tweets so that the same action does not get recorded twice over.

Secondly, the entire process was automated, so the toilet had a list of phrases to tweet each time it got flushed. Initially, the

toilet had a list of eight phrases to choose from, but it needed more variety. The coders decided to give it a list of fifty phrases. Then something happened to the toilet that happens to the best of 1337 h4XX0r rigs. The toilet ran out of RAM to process the phrases, and started behaving oddly. So the coders moved the phrases into another kind of memory, and the problem was solved. Not only is it a toilet that tweets at every flush, it is an open source toilet that tweets at every flush. The instructions for building the toilet are available at tinyurl.com/pyj77t and the code for it is at tinyurl.com/dhwr3p. The instructions are in English, but the code has German comments. Still,

if you can understand the code, you can figure the useful part out, and maybe even learn a little German by reversing the logic of the code. Fortunately, the guys at hacklab stopped right there, that does not mean you shouldn't go further. At the end of the page outlining the instructions for building the tweeting toilet, are hints at further additions to the setup you can make, including acidity and volume sensors. That's enough indulgence.

** Look out for some of the music on next month's DVD though, if 80 tweets per second is the kind of music you are into...*

